

Cognitive Behavioral Therapy (CBT)

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What is cognitive behavioral therapy (CBT)?

Cognitive behavioral therapy (CBT) is a structured, goal-oriented type of [psychotherapy](#) (talk therapy).

Mental health professionals, including [psychologists](#), therapists and counselors, use it to treat or manage mental health conditions and emotional concerns. It's one of the most common and best-studied forms of psychotherapy.

CBT is based on several core principles, including:

During CBT, a mental health professional helps you take a close look at your thoughts and emotions. You'll come to understand how your thoughts affect your actions. Through CBT, you can unlearn negative thoughts and behaviors and learn to adopt healthier thinking patterns and habits.

CBT usually takes place over a limited number of sessions. Using a question-and-answer format, your therapist helps you gain a different perspective. As a result, you learn to respond better to [stress](#), pain and difficult situations.

CBT can be used alone or along with medication and other therapies. Your therapist will customize your treatment based on the issue you're addressing.

What conditions can cognitive behavioral therapy (CBT) treat?

Cognitive behavioral therapy is a valuable tool for treating and managing a wide range of mental health conditions and emotional challenges. People of all ages (including [children](#)) can receive CBT.

Therapists and psychologists use CBT to treat many mental health conditions, including:

When combined with medication, CBT is useful in treating [bipolar disorder](#) and [schizophrenia](#).

Studies have shown that CBT is also effective in helping manage nonpsychological medical conditions, including:

CBT can help people work through everyday challenges and life changes, too. You might seek help for issues such as:

How do I find a CBT therapist?

A therapist can be a psychologist, [psychiatrist](#) (a medical doctor who can prescribe medications), psychiatric nurse, social worker or family therapist.

Finding the right therapist for you is often a time-consuming task. Try not to become discouraged. Talk to people you trust to give you a referral for a therapist who uses cognitive behavioral therapy, whether it's your primary healthcare provider or a friend or family member.

You can also search for therapists online through local and state psychological associations.

Be sure that any therapist you're interested in seeing is a state-certified and licensed mental health professional and that they treat your area of concern (for example, depression, eating disorders, substance use disorders, etc.).

Most therapists' websites list the conditions and problems they treat. If you have questions, call or email the therapist's office before you choose.